

manifold. The food court and related areas will be bigger and better. The number of toilets, washrooms, water points — everything will be a lot more to ensure clean and hygienic facilities along with medical assistance.

Apart from this, we want everyone in Bihar to be able to watch the matches, so we will be setting up fan parks in every district across the state. There will be huge LED screens with food stalls in every district headquarters to make it a public occasion.

One of the things we wanted to do was put up temporary stands with scaffoldings, like at the Paris Olympics, to further increase spectator capacity.

But the feasibility study — conducted by the BSSA with the disaster management authorities and fire department — made it clear that in case of any emergency, evacuation would become an issue. So we dropped the idea because safety comes first.

What were the learnings from the ACT and how have you handled those this time?

To be honest, there wasn't much of a challenge even last year, but yes, some things we have improved this time. The biggest challenge was transporting teams from Bodh Gaya and back, which is now taken care of.

Secondly, crowd management was tricky because although entry was free, people had to book tickets online. What happened was, someone would book a ticket, then share the QR code with friends and family, and all of them would insist on entering with that single code on their respective phones.

This time, we have devised the software in such a way that they cannot forward a ticket to anybody. It is still free, but you will have to book it yourself. That will ensure proper crowd management.

Another challenge was the large swarm of insects under the lights, flooding the entire area including the turf. That was a major nightmare. Now we know what to expect and what to do — the respective agencies have been alerted to control them beforehand.

Apart from hockey, what is the status of the other halls and venues inside the complex?

The indoor halls are all completely ready. As I mentioned, the KIYG really galvanised the process of finishing the work. Kabaddi, fencing, weightlifting, table tennis and others were conducted in those newly constructed halls. Even the athletics track and football ground are ready.

The two biggest structures are the velodrome — that will take some more time — and the cricket stadium. As for cricket, the pitch is laid and ready because it was done by the BCCI itself. We can perhaps host a small local match there. One major pavilion, the VIP block, is almost ready and if all goes well, the completed stadium will be inaugurated by the Hon. Chief Minister by September-end.

What is the long-term plan for the Rajgir Sports Complex?

The plans are already being implemented on the ground.

We have training camps for junior boys and girls in weightlifting, wrestling, athletics and hockey, with athletes staying in hostels and practising under qualified coaches.

The academies are operational, the facilities are being utilised. We are soon going to start the national women's football camp as well.

As for major events, the Asia Cup will be the last one for now — anything else will happen only in 2026 after the Assembly elections.



R. V. MOORTHY